

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH  
*of Los Angeles*

*Pentecost 9*

*Another Kind of Freedom ~ Radical Love*  
*2 August 2026*

*TBD*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020  
Telephone 213.385.1341 – [www.FCCLA.org](http://www.FCCLA.org)

## **The Gathering of the People**

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

*Please note that our services are live streamed at [fccla.org/live](http://fccla.org/live).*

### **Organ Prelude Concert**

**Dr. Abraham Ross, Guest Organist**

*Ave Maria* op. 106 no. 2 – Sigfrid Karg-Elert

*Fantasia super Jesu meine Freude* BWV 713 – J. S. Bach

*Sonata no. 1 in F minor* – Felix Mendelssohn

*Allegro moderato e serio*

*Adagio*

*Andante recitativo*

*Allegro assai veloce*

### **Chiming of the Hour**

#### **Welcome**

**Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

#### **Words of Gathering**

**Janette Tovar & Rev. Fregin**

If we boil down the purpose of all of our living.

If we follow the thread of all our questions.

If we uncover what is beneath all this grief and discovery:

*We find love, love, love,*

*The very heartbeat of God.*

Love, sturdy and steadfast.

*Love, heartbreaking and heart-opening.*

Love, as in, we belong to each other.

*Love, as in, we will let sorrow turn us towards compassion.*

Love, as in, we will let compassion guide us  
towards wise action.

*Love, as in, God is within each living thing.*

Love as in, God moves between us.

*Love, as in, God is the possibility  
that stretches before us.*

This morning, we give thanks for love  
in all its dimensions, as we open our hearts,  
our minds, and our bodies  
in this time set apart.

[adpt/enfleshed]

*Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

**\*Hymn of Gathering**

*Love Now Ascending*

NICAEA

Holy, holy, holy, love now ascending  
Early in the morning our song shall rise to you.  
Holy, holy, holy, joy that has no ending  
Giving, forgiving, breathing life anew.

Holy, holy, holy, love without a limit  
Care that binds creation in sacred unity,  
Holy, holy, holy, birthing every minute,  
Christ, Love's revealer, sets our spirits free.

Holy, holy, holy, infinite compassion,  
Makes a place for every soul in God's eternal reign,  
Holy, holy, holy, truth beyond religion,  
Love that endures should nothing else remain.

Holy, holy, holy, raise your voice in singing,  
Join the cosmic chorus in praise of Love divine,  
Holy, holy, holy, God beyond all naming,  
Echoes our song in harmony sublime. [JBurklo]

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**Rev. Fregin**

God of fresh starts, of new beginnings,  
of renewal and restoration.  
We awake to your grace,  
embraced by love unconditional.

With each new morning you birth possibilities  
in us and around us.  
We are surrounded by Sacred potential  
and we know deep in our hearts,  
there are so many ways to love.

May we rise to this day's call;  
to listen for the aches,  
to give voice to the beauty,  
and to be companions to justice,  
and to drink from the deep well of joy,  
both now and in all the days to come.

May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us -  
Amen and Amen!*

[adpt/m.jadekaiser]

**\*Introit**

*"Love is love is love"*  
Cathedral Choir

ABBIE BETINIS

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

Janette Tovar

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,  
How sacred is your Presence!  
We lean on your guidance.  
We seek your love.  
We open to your transformation.  
Provide us bread in body and spirit  
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.  
Companion us with grace  
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion.,  
repair and accountability.  
We remember those who have supported us  
as we seek to support others  
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.  
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination  
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.  
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.  
Everything that lives, returns to your care.  
Our thanks and honor to you,  
Gracious Web of Existence,  
Our Source and our Home.  
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**\*Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

Though the mystery of God remains beyond grasp,  
the Spirit gifts us with glimpses of justice,  
with touches of love,  
and with whispers of truth.

Always and everywhere,  
the Wisdom of God is being revealed,  
that we might live and love differently together,  
free from the ways that destroy.  
On this day, may we recognize the Holy Mystery that surrounds us  
and reveals the ways of collective liberation - and beauty.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.  
*And also with you!*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

*Please be seated*

**Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition**

This is the Gospel of Radical Love.

*Thanks be to God!*

*from the Gospel of Luke*

**Janette Tovar**

**Prayers with the People**

**Rev. Fregin**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

*Silence*

**Prayer of Our Hearts**

Holy One, deep within our being, we give thanks for life  
and for the love that makes us whole.

No matter where we go, you are with us.

If we wander from love's way out of fear or in pursuit of power,  
you come to find us.

If we are turned away from places we once called home,  
you walk with us on the road to freedom.

If we desire to create places of belonging  
that are just and restorative,  
you empower us with all we need.

If we go looking for what is missing in us,  
you meet us in the searching,  
and lead us on the paths of restoration.

You help us, Holy One, to not grow weary in doing good,  
in telling the truth, in loving one another,  
in practicing and pursuing what is just,  
and in finding renewal in the beauty and delight  
that persists around us.

Holy One, help us to realize you will never stop reminding us  
that always and forever, we are your beloved children,  
no matter where we go.

In these precious moments, we give thanks for the roads we have traveled together,  
and we give thanks for all that is before us.

*Amen and Amen.*

**Meditation Anthem**

"You Are Music" from *Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial*  
Laude

DAVID HARRIS

*"You are music...you are the universe greeting itself for a brief moment." ~Dr. Roger Penrose*

"Introit and Kyrie" from *Requiem in D Minor*  
Cathedral Choir

W.A. MOZART

*"Let perpetual light shine on us. We sing to the God of love, the love that marks our beginning and our ending.  
God have mercy, Christ have mercy."*

**"Beati Quorum Via"**  
Laude

CHARLES VILLIERS STANFORD

*"Blessed are they who walk with God, whose way is steadfast love."*

**Sermon**

***Radical Love***

**Rev. Michael Lehman**

**Invitation to Generosity**

**Janette Tovar**

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give). Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

**Offertory**

**"Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge"**  
Laurel Irene and Dr. Abraham Ross

VINCENZO BELLINI

*"I didn't believe that love could fade so quickly. Perhaps my tears can revive you. Ah! Human thought can't manage to grasp the happiness I feel. I can barely believe my own senses. Love is revived! Let us always unite in a single hope. From this place that we live, we shall build a heaven of love."*

**\*Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator's praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Your name shall sound and praises soar  
till suns shall rise and set no more.  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

**\*Offering Prayer**

**Janette Tovar**

God of Grace and Love, remind us as we leave this time together,  
that you made us in your image  
and filled us with your Spirit of Love.

As we offer all our gifts and talents, O God,  
give us the vision to use your wildly inclusive love,  
so that by our words and our actions,  
we may dismantle the walls of division  
and co-create our lives with your grace and love,  
on this day and on all the days to come.

May it be so.  
***May it be so for all of us!***  
***Amen and Amen.***

***Please be seated***

**Life at First Church**

**Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman**

## Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

The world now is too dangerous  
and too beautiful for anything but love.

May your eyes be so blessed you see God in everyone.  
Your ears, so you hear the cry of the poor.

May your hands be so blessed  
that everything you touch is a sacrament.  
Your lips, so you are speaking nothing but the truth in love.

May your feet be so blessed you run  
to those who need you.

And may your heart be so opened,  
so set on fire, that your love,  
your love, changes everything.

[A Black Rock Prayerbook]

May it forever be so.  
*May it forever be so for all of us!*

## Choral Response

"I Remember, I Believe"  
Cathedral Choir

BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON

## \*Hymn for the Journey

*God Whose Love is Always Stronger*

HYFRYDOL

God whose love is always stronger  
Than our weakness, pride and fear,  
In your world, we pray and wonder  
How to be more faithful here.  
Hate too often grows inside us;  
Fear rules what the nations do.  
So we pray, when life divides us:  
Give us love, God!  
Make us new!

Love is patient, kind and caring.  
Never arrogant or rude,  
Never boastful, all things bearing;  
Love rejoices in the truth.  
When we're caught up in believing  
We will never live in peace,  
Show us Jesus' way of living;  
May our strength in you increase.

May our faith in you be nourished;  
May all people hear your call.  
May our lives be filled with courage  
As we speak your grace for all.

Now emboldened by your Spirit  
Who has given us new birth,  
Give us love, that we may share it  
Till your love renews the earth. [adapt / Carolyn Winfrey Gillette]

## Postlude

**Dr. Abraham Ross**, *Guest Organist*

Fugue in G major K. 574 – W. A. Mozart

### Inside The Music

“Reflecting on almost a decade here at FCCLA, I feel overwhelmed by the magnitude of love and connection I’ve shared in community with you all. The music today are several pieces that I really wanted to sing. They connect around a broader, universal integration of love and being. Some are more obvious, like Abbie Betinis’ “Love Is Love Is Love” that she wrote for simple group singing, though the message is anything but simple in our day and age. The famous “Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge” from Bellini’s “La Sonnambula” is a monster anthem to love. The opera’s finale, it brings everyone together around a believe that love is the central architect of life, and we can hope to love in perpetuity. I wrote “Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial” as a long-form improvisation. We’ll do the last part of it today, which was inspired by the physicist Roger Penrose. I heard him speak passionately about our connection to the universe, ergo, all things. I amended his quote a little for the music. In the actual quote I sourced he says: “You are music. . . You are the universe experiencing itself for a brief moment before dissolving back into the eternal field structure.” Every time I think about this I’m moved. The world around us, everything we know and understand, are expressions of the same eternal field structure. For whatever reason we come into being and then we return to that oneness. That, to me, is the essence of love, and it makes me want to love deeply in order to remain close to the source for the time that I am aware of my place in the universe. I feel like Mozart was experiencing a similar reflection as he wrote his final piece, the “Requiem in D Minor.” The opening is so tender, and even the double fugue in the “Kyrie” rings with depths of passion and promise. Although he chose the text of the death mass for which he was commissioned, the music explodes with the beauties of life and love. It rattles through us reminding us to awaken into the energy of this moment. He’s calling to us still to live and love and be in concert with each other. The simple, elegant beauty of Stanford’s “Beati quorum via” speaks for itself as an expression of commitment to love as a way of life. And I had to program something by Bernice Johnson Reagon today. She is one of the composers whose capacity to communicate deep truths has so consistently marked my time here with you all. I love hearing and singing her music. In this last verse of “I Remember, I Believe” she resonates these other voices by saying “My God called to me in the morning dew, the power of the universe knows my name. Gave me a song to sing and sent me on my way, I raise my voice for justice, and I believe.” The whole song has a careful balance around knowing and unknowing. In the song, she releases that which she can’t fathom into places that won’t weigh her down as she picks up the song that she’s been given and sings it for all to hear. That’s a promise to live by.” ~ *Dr. David Harris*